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# SHILLONG FANS EMBRACE ISL

**T**he Indian Super League's debut fixture in Shillong between NorthEast United and Mumbai City FC (**above**) created an unmissable buzz in the air, laden with promise.

After 10 seasons of endless anticipation, fans in the 'rock capital of India' finally got a glimpse of their favourite players, whom they were used to seeing only within the four corners of a screen.

Packed with 14,000 people, the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium illuminated the dark, foggy evening as it prepared to make history.

Compared to the few games the Diary has attended in the past year, the Shillong crowd stood out due to their sheer love for football, which is deeply rooted in the state.

Almost all the fans the Diary spoke to said



The local crowd stood out due to their sheer love for football, which is **deeply rooted** in the state.

they were most excited to see star signing Alaaeddine Ajaraie (**left**) and hometown hero Redeem Tlang in action. Across the stands from where the Diary stood, the Highlander Brigade (the supporters' club of NEUFC) sang in unison, urging their team on from warm-ups until the final kick of the ball.

The temperature dropping into single digits did not stop the crowd from growing increasingly boisterous as the match progressed.

"We want goals, we want goals..." rang across the stadium.

Despite the 2-0 loss for the home side, its faithful fans assembled outside the stadium to lift the players' spirits after a disappointing game.